

Current US motorcycle and bicycle helmet laws

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Helmet use laws overview | History of US motorcycle helmet laws

Twenty states and the District of Columbia have motorcycle helmet laws that require all riders to wear a helmet. Twenty-seven states have a motorcycle helmet law that only require some riders to wear a helmet. Three states (Illinois, Iowa, and New Hampshire) do not have a motorcycle helmet law.

Low-power cycle (LPC) is a generic term used by IIHS to cover motor-driven cycles, mopeds, scooters, and various other 2-wheeled cycles excluded from the motorcycle definition. While state laws vary, a cycle with an engine displacement of 50 cubic centimeters or less, brake horsepower of 2 or less, and top speeds of 30 mph or less typically is considered an LPC. Twenty-two states have motorcycle helmet laws that cover all low-power cycles. Twenty-five states and the District of Columbia have laws that cover some low-power cycles.

Twenty-one states and the District of Columbia have bicycle helmet laws that require some young bicyclists to wear a helmet. Local law may require helmet use for some or all bicyclists.

- Table
- Map: motorcyclists covered
- Map: low-power cycles covered
- Map: bicyclists covered



State	Motorcycle helmets	Does the motorcycle helmet law cover all low-power cycles?	Bicycle helmets
Alabama	all riders	yes	15 and younger
Alaska	17 and younger ¹	yes	no law
Arizona	17 and younger	some	no law
Arkansas	20 and younger	yes	no law
California	all riders	yes	17 and younger
Colorado	17 and younger and passengers 17 and younger	yes	no law
Connecticut	17 and younger	yes	15 and younger
Delaware	18 and younger	some	17 and younger
District of Columbia	all riders	some	15 and younger
Florida	20 and younger ²	some	15 and younger
Georgia	all riders	some	15 and younger
Hawaii	17 and younger	some	15 and younger
Idaho	17 and younger	some	no law
Illinois	no law	no law	no law
Indiana	17 and younger	yes	no law
Iowa	no law	no law	no law

Kansas	17 and younger	some	no law
Kentucky	20 and younger ³	some	no law
Louisiana	all riders	yes	11 and younger
Maine	17 and younger ⁴	some	15 and younger
Maryland	all riders	some	15 and younger
Massachusetts	all riders	yes	1–16 (riding with children younger than 1 prohibited)
Michigan	all riders	some	no law
Minnesota	17 and younger ⁵	yes	no law
Mississippi	all riders	yes	no law
Missouri	all riders	some	no law
Montana	17 and younger	some	no law
Nebraska	all riders	yes	no law
Nevada	all riders	some	no law
New Hampshire	no law	no law	15 and younger
New Jersey	all riders	yes	16 and younger
New Mexico	17 and younger	some	17 and younger
New York	all riders	some	1–13 (riding with children younger than 1 prohibited)
North Carolina	all riders	yes	15 and younger
North Dakota	17 and younger ⁶	yes	no law
Ohio	17 and younger ⁷	yes	no law
Oklahoma	17 and younger	some	no law
Oregon	all riders	yes	15 and younger
Pennsylvania	20 and younger ⁸	some	11 and younger
Rhode Island	20 and younger ⁹	some	15 and younger
South Carolina	20 and younger	yes	no law
South Dakota	17 and younger	yes	no law
Tennessee	all riders	yes	15 and younger
Texas	20 and younger ¹⁰	some	no law
Utah	17 and younger	yes	no law
Vermont	all riders	some	no law
Virginia	all riders	some	no law
Washington	all riders	yes	no law
West Virginia	all riders	some	14 and younger
Wisconsin	17 and younger ¹¹	some	no law
Wyoming	17 and younger	some	no law

¹Alaska's motorcycle helmet use law covers passengers of all ages, operators younger than 18, and operators with instructional permits.

²In Florida, the law requires that all riders younger than 21 years wear helmets, without exception. Those 21 years and older may ride without helmets only if they can show proof that they are covered by a medical insurance policy.

³In Kentucky, the law requires that all riders younger than 21 years wear helmets, without exception. Those 21 years and older may ride without helmets only if they can show proof that they are covered by a medical insurance policy. Motorcycle helmet laws in Kentucky also cover operators with instructional/learner's permits.

⁴Motorcycle helmet laws in Maine cover operators with instructional/learner's permits. Maine's motorcycle helmet use law also covers passengers 17 years and younger and passengers if their operators are required to wear a helmet.

⁵Motorcycle helmet laws in Minnesota cover operators with instructional/learner's permits.

⁶North Dakota's motorcycle helmet use law covers all passengers traveling with operators who are covered by the law.

⁷Ohio's motorcycle helmet use law covers all operators during the first year of licensure and all passengers of operators who are covered by the law.

⁸Pennsylvania's motorcycle helmet use law covers all operators during the first two years of licensure unless the operator has completed the safety course approved by PennDOT or the Motorcycle Safety Foundation.

⁹Rhode Island's motorcycle helmet use law covers all passengers (regardless of age) and all operators during the first year of licensure (regardless of age).

¹⁰Texas exempts riders 21 years or older if they can either show proof of successfully completing a motorcycle operator training and safety course or can show proof of having a medical insurance policy. A peace officer may not stop or detain a person who is the operator of or a passenger on a motorcycle for the sole purpose of determining whether the person has successfully completed the motorcycle operator training and safety course or is covered by a health insurance plan.

¹¹Motorcycle helmet laws in Wisconsin cover operators with instructional/learner's permits.